

Section B Option 3: Religion, belief and faith

This option focuses on debates in contemporary society through a detailed study of religion, belief and faith. Learners have the opportunity to explore the role of religion in an increasingly global society. Learners can also consider patterns and trends of religiosity both in the UK and on a more global scale. It aims to give an understanding of different theoretical approaches to the study of religion, belief and faith.

Key questions	Content	Learners should:
1. How are religion, belief and faith defined and measured?	Defining religion, faith and belief Different types of religious institutions and movements: • churches and denominations • sects and cults • new religious movements • new age movements • religious fundamentalism Measuring religion, faith and belief: • religious belief • religiosity • belief without belonging • vicarious religion	consider the complexity of measuring religion, belief and faith and consider the advantages and disadvantages of each measure.
2. What is the role of religion, belief and faith?	Theoretical views of the role of religion, belief and faith for the individual and for society: • functionalism • Marxism • neo-Marxism • Weberianism • feminism • phenomenology • postmodernism Theoretical views of the relationship between religion and social change: • functionalism • Marxism • neo-Marxism • Weberianism	consider the theoretical debate on whether religion is positive or negative and whether religion is a conservative force, or a force for change.